this country assigned you and the media the task of finding the next prime minister'?' When I repeated the question of whether the next PM would be from Gujarat, his answer was cryptic. 'I am only focused on Gujarat and dream of building a strong state.'

Interestingly, I had asked him a similar question about his prime ministerial ambitions during the *Hindustan Times* Summit in 2007. Then, too, he had spoken of his love for Gujarat and how he was not looking beyond the state. Then, I had believed him. Now, his responses seemed to be more mechanical and lacking conviction. As he turned away from me, I could see a celebratory glint in his eyes—it suggested to me that, with victory in Gujarat almost assured, Modi was now ready to stake a claim for the biggest prize in Indian politics.